# Give Them Back Their Wonder

A Parent's Guide to Rescuing Your Kids from Digital Noise This School Break, with 100 Screen-Free Games That Bring the Laughter Back

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Written with the help of AI tools and carefully edited. Illustrations created with the help of AI.

# Before the Break Begins

School breaks are supposed to be a rest. For many families, they turn into something else: long, shapeless days where screens slowly fill every gap. A tablet at breakfast. A game "just until lunch." Videos while you cook. A show before bed. By the third day, everyone is irritable, the kids are bouncing off the walls, and you're wondering how to get through two more weeks.

If that sounds familiar, you're not a bad parent, and your children are not "addicted." You are living in a world that was designed to capture attention, and school holidays remove the structure that usually keeps that pull in check.

This book is a practical plan for a calmer, more connected winter break. It is not about banning technology or feeling guilty. Screens are part of modern life, and some screen time can be fun, relaxing and even educational. The goal is balance: protecting your children from the *digital noise* (the endless, fast, attention-grabbing content that leaves them wired and moody) while making room for play, boredom, creativity and family time.

You will find:

- Why screens are so hard to put down, explained simply
- A step-by-step plan to set up your family's "break rules" before the first day
- Scripts for the hardest moments, including meltdowns when screens go off
- A daily rhythm that gives the days shape without over-scheduling

- **100 screen-free games and activities**, sorted by age, energy level and setup time
- Printable-style charts, checklists and a family agreement

A note for all parents: every family is different. Ages, work schedules, health, budgets and space all shape what is realistic. Take what works and leave the rest. A 20 percent improvement is still a real win.

# Chapter 1: Why Screens Are So Hard to Put Down



Before you can change a habit, it helps to understand it, and to explain it to your children in a way that makes sense.

## Designed to keep us watching

Many apps, games and video platforms are designed to keep people engaged for as long as possible. Common features include:

- **Autoplay:** the next video starts before you've decided whether you want it.
- **Endless feeds:** there is no natural "end," no last page.
- **Rewards and surprises:** points, levels, loot boxes, likes and streaks that keep you coming back.

- **Short, fast content:** clips that change every few seconds make slower activities feel boring by comparison.

None of this means screens are evil. It simply means that stopping is genuinely hard, for adults as much as for children. When your child melts down after the tablet goes off, they are not being dramatic; they are struggling with something that was built to be hard to leave.

## How children explain it

Young children often can't tell you "I feel overstimulated." Instead you might see:

- Irritability or tears when screens are turned off
- Trouble falling asleep
- Saying "I'm bored" within minutes of any non-screen activity
- Less patience for slower play like puzzles, drawing or books
- Restlessness and wild energy after long screen sessions

These are signals, not character flaws. They usually ease noticeably after a few days of better balance.

## Explaining it to your kids

Children cooperate far more when they understand the "why." Try something like:

> *"Some games and videos are made by really clever people whose job is to make them hard to stop. That's why it feels so tricky when we turn them off. It's not your fault. Our job as a family is*

> *to be even cleverer, and to make sure screens are something we choose, not something that chooses us."*

For older children, you can go further: talk about autoplay, streaks and how platforms make money from attention. Many tweens and teens find this genuinely interesting, and it makes them allies rather than opponents.

# Chapter 2: Your Family Break Plan

The biggest mistake parents make is trying to set screen rules in the middle of the holiday, when everyone is already tired and screens are already in hands. The secret is to decide everything *before* the break begins.

## Step 1: Decide your family's goals

Sit down with your partner, co-parent or just yourself and answer:

**How do we want this break to feel?** (e.g. relaxed, playful, outdoorsy, connected)

**What do we want more of?**

**What do we want less of?**

**What screen use is fine with us?** (e.g. a family movie, calls with grandparents, one show a day)

## Step 2: Choose a screen approach

There is no single right approach. Here are four that work well for different families:

**1. Screen windows.** Screens are available only during set times, for example 4–5 p.m. and a family film on weekends. Clear and predictable.

**2. Earn-and-choose.** Screen time is unlocked after the "daily basics": getting dressed, outdoor time, a chore and some creative play. Good for school-age kids.

**3. Screen-free mornings.** No screens before lunch. Mornings are for play, outside time and activities. Afternoons are more flexible.

**4. The family digital detox.** A full break from personal screens for a set number of days, with family movies as a shared exception. Great for a reset, but plan it carefully.

**Our approach this break:**

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## Step 3: Make it visible

Children follow rules better when they can see them. Write your plan on a big sheet of paper or use the family agreement in this book. Stick it on the fridge.

## Step 4: Prepare the environment

Your home will do half the work for you if you set it up well:

- **Create a "screen home."** A basket or drawer where devices live when not in use, ideally outside bedrooms.
- **Turn off autoplay** on streaming services and video apps.
- **Use built-in controls** to set time limits on devices.
- **Set up "invitation stations"**: a table with art supplies, a basket of books, a puzzle half done, building blocks out on the floor.

Visible options get used.

- **Prepare an "I'm bored" jar** (see Chapter 5).
- **Stock up** on cheap basics: paper, tape, cardboard boxes, string, flour, salt, food coloring, a deck of cards.

## Step 5: Tell the kids before the break

Hold a short family meeting a day or two before school ends. Explain the plan with enthusiasm, not as a punishment. Let children help choose activities, outings and their screen windows. People support what they help create.

## Practice: Our family break agreement

**This break, our family wants to:**

**Screens are for:**

**Screen times:**

**Screens live in:**

**When screen time ends, we:**

**Grown-ups promise to:**

**Signed:**

# Chapter 3: When the Screen Goes Off

The moment a screen turns off is often the hardest moment of the day. Here's how to make it easier.

## Give a warning, and make it concrete

"Five more minutes" means very little to a young child. Try:

- "After this episode ends, it's time to turn it off."
- "When you finish this level, we'll save and stop."
- Use a visual timer the child can see.

Warnings work best when the end is tied to a natural stopping point.

## Have a "landing activity" ready

The transition from screen to nothing is brutal. The transition from screen to *something* is much gentler. Before screen time ends, have the next thing ready: a snack, a walk to the mailbox, a game you will play together, a bath.

> *"When the show ends, we're going to make hot chocolate and play one round of Uno."*

## Stay calm during the meltdown

If your child gets upset:

1. Stay close and calm. Your calm is contagious.

2. Name the feeling: "You're really disappointed. You wanted to keep playing."
3. Hold the boundary: "It's off for now. You can play again tomorrow at four."
4. Offer connection, not lectures: a hug, sitting together, the landing activity.

Avoid bargaining in the heat of the moment ("Okay, ten more minutes…"). Every time the rule bends under pressure, children learn that a bigger meltdown works. Consistency in the first three days makes the rest of the break much easier.

## For older kids and teens

Teens need more autonomy and respect. Involve them in setting limits, focus on specific concerns (sleep, family time, mood) rather than total control, and model the behavior you're asking for. Agree on "phone-free zones" like the dinner table and family outings, and keep them yourself.

## Practice: Our landing activities

List five quick, easy things your family can do right after screen time ends.

# Chapter 4: A Daily Rhythm That Works

Unstructured days are where screens creep in. But over-scheduled days are exhausting for everyone. The answer is a *rhythm*: a predictable shape to the day, with flexibility inside it.




## A simple holiday rhythm

Here is a rhythm many families find works well during winter break:

- **Morning:** slow start, breakfast together, get dressed, a small chore.
- **Mid-morning:** outside time (even 30 minutes counts), or an outing.
- **Lunch.**

- **Early afternoon:** quiet time: books, audiobooks, drawing, puzzles, rest.
- **Mid-afternoon:** screen window, if part of your plan.
- **Late afternoon:** active play, helping with dinner, a game.
- **Evening:** dinner together, bath, stories, early-ish bed.

Write your own version and put it on the fridge. Young children especially thrive on knowing "what comes next."

**Our daily rhythm**

Morning: [[lines:1]]

Mid-morning: [[lines:1]]

Lunch: [[lines:1]]

Early afternoon: [[lines:1]]

Mid-afternoon: [[lines:1]]

Late afternoon: [[lines:1]]

Evening: [[lines:1]]

## The magic of outdoor time

If you only change one thing this break, make it this: get outside every day, whatever the weather. Fresh air and movement improve mood, sleep and behavior for almost every child. Wrap up warm, put on boots, and go: a walk, a playground, a nature hunt, puddle jumping, a bike ride.

## Theme days

Theme days add excitement without much effort. Ideas:

- **Monday Maker Day:** crafts, building, inventions
- **Tuesday Kitchen Day:** cooking and baking together
- **Wednesday Adventure Day:** an outing somewhere new
- **Thursday Game Day:** board games, card games, a home tournament
- **Friday Fort and Film Night:** build a blanket fort, watch a family movie inside it
- **Weekend:** family time, visits, rest

## Don't forget yourself

If you're working through the break, or simply exhausted, you need a plan too. Build in time when children play independently, swap childcare with another parent, and lower your standards for tidiness. A happy, rested parent matters more than a perfect itinerary.

# Chapter 5: Boredom Is Not an Emergency

"I'm bored!" might be the most dreaded sentence of any school holiday. But boredom isn't a problem to be fixed instantly. It's often the doorway to creativity.

When children have nothing pre-made to entertain them, they start inventing: games, stories, structures, worlds. That uncomfortable gap is exactly where imagination grows. Many adults remember their most creative childhood moments as the ones that started with "There's nothing to do."

## Respond calmly

When your child says "I'm bored," try:

- "That's okay. I bet you'll think of something."
- "Boredom is your brain getting ready for an idea."
- "Want to pick from the jar?"

Resist the urge to immediately offer a screen or a long list of options. Give it ten minutes. Often, play begins on its own.

## The "I'm bored" jar

Write simple activities on slips of paper (you'll find 100 ideas in Chapter 14) and put them in a jar. When a child is stuck, they pick one. Make it a rule that they have to give it a real try for 15 minutes. Use different colored paper for indoor, outdoor and quiet activities.

## Practice: Our jar starter list

Write the first ten activities you'll put in your family's jar.

# Chapter 6: What Changes When the Screens Go Quiet

Parents who try a calmer, lower-screen break often describe the same pattern. The first two or three days are the hardest. There is more whining, more "I'm bored," more testing of the new rules. Then, somewhere around day three or four, something shifts. The children start playing for longer stretches. The house gets louder in a good way. Bedtime gets easier.

Knowing this pattern in advance helps enormously, because the hardest days come first. If you expect them, you will not mistake them for failure.

## Day one to three: the dip

When a strong source of stimulation is reduced, the brain notices. Everything else feels slow and dull by comparison. Children may:

- Follow you around asking when screen time starts
- Say that every activity is "boring" before trying it
- Have more tears or tantrums around transitions
- Seem restless and unable to settle

This does not mean the plan is wrong. It means their attention is recalibrating. Your job during the dip is simple: stay calm, keep the rhythm, offer connection, and do not negotiate the rules every hour.

## Day four onwards: the lift

As the days go on, many families notice:

- Longer, more creative play, often with toys that had been ignored for months
- Siblings playing together more (and yes, sometimes fighting more, because they are interacting more)
- Children asking to help with "real" tasks like cooking, building or fixing
- Easier evenings and earlier sleep
- More conversation at mealtimes

Not every family sees every change, and every child is different. But almost every family notices *something*. Make a point of naming it out loud: "Did you notice we've been laughing a lot today?" Children learn to value what we notice.

## Practice: Your before-and-after notes

On day one, write three sentences about how your family feels. On day seven, write three more. You may be surprised.

**Day 1 – how our home feels:**

**Day 7 – how our home feels:**

# Chapter 7: Screens by Age – What Works for Little Ones, Big Kids and Tweens

Every age needs a slightly different approach. A two-year-old and an eleven-year-old live in completely different digital worlds. Here is what tends to work at each stage.

## Ages 2–4: Keep it simple, short and shared

For toddlers and preschoolers, the most valuable things are real-world play, movement, language and connection with caring adults. Screens can't replace any of these, so during the break:

- **Keep screen time short and predictable**, for example one short show after lunch.
- **Watch together when you can.** Talk about what you see: "Look, the bear is sad. Why do you think he's sad?"
- **Choose slow-paced shows** over fast, flashing content.
- **Avoid screens in the hour before bed**, when they make settling harder.
- **Expect big feelings when screens end**, and stay close and calm.

Little ones thrive on simple, repeated play: water play at the sink, play dough, stacking blocks, "helping" with laundry, reading the same book for the tenth time. Repetition is not boring to them. It's how they learn.

## Ages 5–7: Add choice and responsibility

Early school-age children love having some control. This is a great age for:

- **A visual screen plan** they can see and understand, for example a chart with picture icons.
- **Choosing their screen time slot** from options you offer: "After lunch or before dinner?"
- **Earning screen time** after the daily basics: dressed, outside, a chore, something creative.
- **Learning to stop at natural endings:** finishing an episode, saving a game.

This is also the age when kids start comparing: "But Emma has a tablet in her room!" A calm, consistent answer works best: "Every family has different rules. In our family, tablets live in the kitchen."

## Ages 8–12: Involve them as partners

Older children and tweens can understand *why* screens are hard to put down, and many find it genuinely interesting. With this age group:

- **Explain how apps and games are designed** to hold attention (autoplay, streaks, rewards).
- **Write the break rules together.** Let them propose limits, and negotiate within your bottom line.
- **Respect their social world.** For many tweens, messaging friends is how they stay connected. Agree on times for this rather than banning it outright.
- **Give them real responsibility:** planning a family day out, cooking a meal, teaching a younger sibling a game.

- **Agree on phone-free zones and times** that everyone, including adults, follows: meals, car rides, the hour before bed.

## A note on gaming

Many children love video games, and games can be social, creative and challenging. During the break, gaming can be part of the plan without taking over:

- Prefer games with natural stopping points over endless ones.
- Agree on when sessions end before they start.
- Watch out for games designed around constant purchases or rewards; talk with your child about how they work.
- Balance gaming with physical play every day.

## Practice: Our plan by age

**Child's name and age:**

**Screen time that works for them:**

**Their favorite non-screen activities:**

**What helps them when screens end:**

# Chapter 8: Good Screen Time – Yes, It Exists

This book is not anti-screen. Some screen time brings families together, teaches something real, or connects children with people they love. The goal is to make screen time a *choice*, not a default. Here's what good screen time can look like.

## Family movie night

A shared film, with popcorn and blankets, is a completely different experience from three children on three separate devices. Make it an event:

- Let a different family member choose each time.
- Build a blanket fort or make "cinema tickets."
- Pause halfway for a snack break and a quick chat about the story.
- Talk afterwards: "Which character would you want to be? What would you have done differently?"

## Video calls with family far away

Calls with grandparents, cousins or friends who live far away are one of the best uses of a screen. Make them interactive:

- Read a story to grandma, or let her read to them.
- Show a drawing, a Lego build or a new trick.
- Play a simple game together: I spy, twenty questions, rock-paper-scissors.

## Creating, not only consuming

Screens can be tools for making things. Children can:

- Record a "cooking show" while baking with you
- Make a stop-motion film with toys
- Take photos on a nature walk and make a small album
- Write and illustrate a digital story
- Learn a song and record it for a relative

## Learning something they're curious about

A video about how volcanoes work, a tutorial on drawing a dog, a documentary about penguins: these can spark real curiosity. The difference from endless scrolling is intention. You choose it, watch it, then turn it off and *do something* with what you learned.

## Practice: Our good screen time list

Write five screen activities your family agrees are "good screen time."

# Chapter 9: The Working Parent's Survival Plan

Not every parent gets the winter break off. If you are working, at home or away, while the children are out of school, a screen-light break can feel impossible. It isn't, but it needs a different plan.

## Accept that screens may do some babysitting

Let's be honest: if you have an important meeting and two bored children, a show is a perfectly reasonable tool. The goal is not zero screens. It's *planned* screens. Decide in advance when screens will help you most, for example during your most important calls, and protect the rest of the day.

## Build independent play stations

Children can play alone for longer when the setup invites them. Before a work day, prepare:

- **A "busy box" for each child:** a puzzle, a coloring book, a small craft kit, a few toys they haven't seen in a while.
- **A building corner** with blocks, Lego or cardboard and tape.
- **An audiobook or music** playing in the background.
- **A snack station** they can reach themselves.

Rotate the busy boxes every few days so they stay exciting.

## Use your breaks wisely

Short, focused bursts of your attention go a long way. Ten minutes of fully present play at mid-morning, a lunch together at the table, and a short walk in the afternoon can carry children through longer periods of independent play.

## Share the load

- Swap childcare with a friend or neighbor: you take the children one morning, they take yours another.
- Ask grandparents or relatives for a day or half-day.
- Look for local holiday clubs, library events or community activities.

## Practice: My work-day plan

**My most important work hours:**

**Planned screen time during those hours:**

**Busy boxes / play stations I'll prepare:**

**My short connection breaks:**

**Who can help me on which days:**

# Chapter 10: Grandparents, Relatives and Other People's Rules

The holidays often mean visits: grandparents, cousins, family friends. Other homes have other rules. Grandparents may hand over a tablet to keep the peace, or cousins may spend the whole visit on their phones.

## Talk before you visit

A friendly conversation in advance prevents most conflicts:

> *"We're trying to have a calmer, low-screen break this year. The kids would love to bake with you or play cards. Would that work?"*

Most grandparents are delighted to be asked to *do* something with the children. Suggest specific activities: teaching a family recipe, playing an old board game, sharing photo albums, going for a walk.

## Bring the fun with you

Pack a small bag of activities for visits: a deck of cards, a travel game, drawing supplies, a book. When there's something easy to do, screens are less tempting for everyone.

## Let some things go

You can't control every home. If cousins are on their phones or grandpa puts a film on, it's okay. A few hours of different rules won't

undo your plan. Focus on what happens in your own home and on the overall rhythm of the break.

## Practice: Our visit plan

**Who we're visiting:**

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**What I'll say beforehand:**

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**Activities we'll bring:**

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# Chapter 11: Travel Days and Car Rides Without the Tablet

Long journeys are where many families feel they have no choice but to hand over a device. Screens can certainly help on a long trip, but a mix of activities makes travel days calmer and often more fun.

## Car games that need nothing

- **I spy** with colors for little ones ("I spy something red")
- **The alphabet game:** find each letter on signs, in order
- **Twenty questions**
- **License plate hunt:** spot plates from different places
- **Story chain:** each person adds one sentence to a story
- **Would you rather:** "Would you rather have a pet dragon or a pet unicorn?"
- **Sing-alongs** with family favorites

## A travel activity bag

Prepare one bag per child with small, new surprises they can open at intervals ("one surprise every hour"):

- Sticker books and reusable sticker scenes
- A clipboard with paper and crayons
- Magnetic travel games
- Small puzzles or activity pages (like the ones in this book)

- A favorite soft toy and a small blanket
- Audiobooks and podcasts for children

## Planning the screen time

If screens are part of your travel plan, decide when. For example: "After lunch, you can watch two episodes." Knowing it's coming makes the rest of the journey easier and prevents constant asking.

## Practice: Our travel plan

# Chapter 12: Gifts That Aren't Screens

The holidays are also a time of gifts, and the gifts we choose shape how children spend their time in the weeks that follow. Here are ideas that invite play, creativity and connection.

**For ages 2–4:** wooden blocks, play kitchen accessories, simple puzzles, picture books, a dress-up box, play dough tools, a small indoor tent, a ride-on toy.

**For ages 5–7:** building sets, craft kits, a first board game, a magnifying glass and bug catcher, a beginner's cookbook, a scooter, a puppet theater, an art easel.

**For ages 8–12:** a science kit, a more complex board game, a sketchbook with good pencils, a book series, a model kit, a musical instrument, a camera for photography projects, a sports item for a new hobby.

**Experience gifts for any age:** a museum visit, tickets to a show, a day trip, a class (swimming, pottery, cooking), a "special day" with one parent.

**The best gift of all:** time. A handmade voucher for "a pancake breakfast with Dad" or "one afternoon of whatever you choose with Mom" is often remembered for years.

# Chapter 13: When It's More Than a Habit

For most children, screen struggles during the holidays are a normal reaction to very engaging technology. Occasionally, though, there are signs that something deeper is going on and that it's worth talking to your child's doctor, school counselor or a family professional.

Consider seeking advice if, over several weeks, you notice that your child:

- Becomes extremely distressed, aggressive or panicked whenever screens are limited
- Loses interest in almost all other activities and friendships
- Has serious sleep problems linked to device use
- Is secretive or deceptive about screen use in ways that worry you
- Seems anxious, low or withdrawn, and uses screens to escape those feelings
- Has encountered something online that upset or frightened them

Reaching out is not overreacting. It's what caring parents do. And if your child ever tells you about something upsetting online, the most important response is calm: "Thank you for telling me. You're not in trouble. Let's figure this out together."

# Chapter 14: 100 Screen-Free Games and Activities

Here they are: one hundred ideas to fill a winter break with play. Each one is marked with a suggested age range and how much setup it needs. Most need nothing more than what you already have at home.

**Key:** setup time (quick / medium / project) · Ages are just a guide; adapt freely.



## How to use this list

Don't try to do everything. A hundred ideas is a menu, not a to-do list. Here are a few ways families use it:

- **Pick five favorites** at the start of the break and write them on the fridge. When someone says "I'm bored," point to the list.

- **Let children choose.** Read the list together and let each child circle the activities they want to try. Children engage far more with plans they helped make.
- **Match the activity to the energy.** Wild energy after lunch? Choose from the active games. Tired and grumpy at 5 p.m.? Choose something from the quiet list.
- **Prepare the night before.** Many activities work best when materials are ready to go: dough made, boxes collected, paper out on the table.
- **Repeat the hits.** If something works, do it again. Children love repetition, and a favorite game played ten times is ten good afternoons.
- **Mix in "nothing" time.** Not every hour needs an activity. Free, unstructured time is where some of the best play happens.

Most activities need only things you already have at home. Where something needs a little preparation, you'll find step-by-step instructions in the chapter that follows the list.

## Active Indoor Games (for wild energy and rainy days)

1. **Freeze dance.** Play music; when it stops, everyone freezes. *Ages 2+ · quick*
2. **Indoor obstacle course.** Cushions to jump, chairs to crawl under, a tape line to balance on. *3+ · medium*
3. **Balloon keepy-uppy.** Don't let the balloon touch the floor. Add rules: only elbows, only heads. *2+ · quick*

4. **Animal walks race.** Bear crawl, crab walk, frog jumps, penguin waddle across the room. *3+ · quick*
5. **Sock basketball.** Rolled-up socks into a laundry basket. Move it farther each round. *3+ · quick*
6. **Hallway bowling.** Plastic bottles as pins, a soft ball to roll. *3+ · quick*
7. **Simon says.** The classic. Let the kids be Simon too. *3+ · quick*
8. **Tape hopscotch.** Masking tape on the floor; hop through numbers or letters. *4+ · quick*
9. **Laser maze.** Criss-cross string or crepe paper in a hallway; get through without touching. *5+ · medium*
10. **Pillow fort war.** Two forts, soft "snowballs" of rolled socks. *5+ · medium*
11. **Kids' yoga story.** Act out a story with yoga poses: tree, mountain, cat, cobra. *3+ · quick*
12. **Musical statues, musical cushions.** Classic party games that never get old. *3+ · quick*

## Outdoor Winter Fun

1. **Snowman family.** Build one snow person for each member of the family. *3+ · quick*
2. **Snow painting.** Spray bottles filled with water and food coloring. *3+ · quick*
3. **Snow angels and footprint art.** Make patterns, letters or giant pictures with footprints. *2+ · quick*
4. **Ice suncatchers.** Freeze water with leaves, berries and twigs in a pie dish with a string loop. Hang outside. *3+ · project (overnight)*

5. **Nature scavenger hunt.** A pinecone, something red, a feather, three different leaves, an interesting stone. *3+ · quick*
6. **Bird feeder making.** Pinecones with peanut butter (or a seed-butter alternative) and birdseed. *3+ · medium*
7. **Winter walk bingo.** Make a bingo card: a dog, a chimney with smoke, a red door, a bird, a snowflake. *4+ · quick*
8. **Puddle (or snow) jumping contest.** Wellies essential. *2+ · quick*
9. **Sledding or cardboard sliding.** Any small slope will do. *3+ · quick*
10. **Track detectives.** Look for animal footprints in snow or mud. Guess who made them. *4+ · quick*
11. **Night walk with flashlights.** Look at the stars, holiday lights or the moon. *3+ · quick*
12. **Backyard camping hour.** Blankets, a thermos of cocoa and a flashlight. *4+ · medium*

## Kitchen Activities (cooking counts as learning!)

1. **Decorate cookies.** Plain cookies, icing, sprinkles. Maximum mess, maximum joy. *2+ · medium*
2. **Make pizza faces.** Ready dough or flatbreads; toppings become eyes, noses and hair. *3+ · medium*
3. **Homemade playdough.** Flour, salt, water, oil and food coloring. *2+ · quick*
4. **Salt dough ornaments.** Cut shapes, bake, paint. Hang on the tree. *3+ · project*
5. **Fruit kebabs.** Threading practice and a healthy snack. *3+ · quick*

6. **Hot chocolate bar.** Set up toppings; everyone designs their own. *3+ · quick*
7. **Kids' café.** Children make a menu, take orders and serve snacks to the family. *5+ · medium*
8. **Bake bread together.** Kneading is a wonderful sensory activity. *5+ · project*
9. **Homemade lemonade or smoothies.** Measuring, pouring and taste testing. *4+ · quick*
10. **Popcorn experiments.** Sweet, salty, cinnamon, cheese: vote for the best. *4+ · quick*

## Creative and Craft Projects

1. **Cardboard box city.** Boxes become houses, shops, cars and a parking garage. *3+ · project*
2. **Paper snowflakes.** Fold, cut, unfold, gasp. *4+ · quick*
3. **Handmade cards** for grandparents, neighbors, teachers. *3+ · quick*
4. **Collage from magazines** around a theme: dream home, favorite foods, animals. *4+ · quick*
5. **Rock painting.** Paint stones to hide on walks for others to find. *3+ · medium*
6. **Make a puppet show.** Socks or paper-bag puppets and a cardboard stage. *4+ · project*
7. **Bead jewelry.** Bracelets for every family member. *4+ · quick*
8. **Weave on a cardboard loom.** Yarn, cardboard and patience. *6+ · medium*

9. **Draw a giant mural.** Tape a long roll of paper to the floor or wall. *2+ · quick*
10. **Make a family flag or crest.** What symbols represent your family? *5+ · medium*
11. **Paper airplanes contest.** Longest flight, best loop, best decoration. *5+ · quick*
12. **Origami.** Start with simple animals. *6+ · quick*
13. **Build a marble run** from toilet-paper tubes taped to a wall. *5+ · medium*
14. **Leaf or pinecone creatures.** Nature finds plus googly eyes. *3+ · quick*

## Pretend Play and Imagination

1. **Blanket fort.** Chairs, blankets, cushions, fairy lights. Read, eat or nap inside. *2+ · medium*
2. **Restaurant.** Menus, aprons, a play kitchen or real snacks. *3+ · medium*
3. **Post office.** Write letters, decorate envelopes, deliver to every room. *4+ · medium*
4. **Doctor or vet clinic** for stuffed animals. *3+ · quick*
5. **Space mission.** A cardboard rocket, a countdown and an alien planet in the living room. *4+ · medium*
6. **Treasure hunt.** Clues hidden around the house leading to a small prize. *4+ · medium*
7. **Shop.** Price tags, play money, a checkout counter. Great for early math. *4+ · medium*
8. **Fashion show** with dress-up clothes and a "runway." *3+ · quick*

9. **Toy hospital, toy school, toy wedding.** Let the stuffed animals live their lives. *3+ · quick*
10. **Make a movie (without a screen).** Write a script, design costumes, perform it live. *6+ · project*

## Board Games, Card Games and Puzzles

1. **Family game tournament.** A different game every day, with a leaderboard on the fridge. *4+ · quick*
2. **Go Fish, Snap, Crazy Eights, War.** All you need is one deck of cards. *4+ · quick*
3. **Memory game** with cards or homemade picture tiles. *3+ · quick*
4. **Jigsaw puzzle** on a table where anyone can add a piece. *4+ · quick*
5. **Dominoes:** play, or line them up and topple them. *4+ · quick*
6. **Tic-tac-toe championship** on paper. *4+ · quick*
7. **Dots and boxes.** A paper-and-pencil classic. *5+ · quick*
8. **Hangman** with holiday words. *6+ · quick*
9. **Charades.** Act out animals, movies, jobs. *5+ · quick*
10. **Pictionary on paper.** Draw and guess. *5+ · quick*
11. **Twenty questions.** "Is it an animal? Is it bigger than a car?" *5+ · quick*
12. **Make your own board game.** Design the board, the rules, the pieces. *6+ · project*

## Quiet and Calm Activities

1. **Audiobook afternoon.** Lie on cushions and listen together. *3+ · quick*
2. **Library visit.** Let each child choose a stack of books. *2+ · quick*
3. **Reading picnic.** Blanket on the floor, snacks and books. *2+ · quick*
4. **Coloring and mandala pages.** Calming for kids and adults. *3+ · quick*
5. **Sticker scenes.** Create a whole story with stickers. *3+ · quick*
6. **Sensory bin.** Rice, pasta or dried beans with scoops and small toys. *2+ (supervised) · quick*
7. **Listening walk.** Walk quietly and count how many different sounds you hear. *3+ · quick*
8. **Gratitude jar.** Each day, everyone writes or draws one good thing. *4+ · quick*
9. **Stargazing.** Look for the brightest star, the moon, a constellation. *4+ · quick*
10. **Calm-down breathing games:** blow "birthday candles," smell the "hot cocoa," blow it cool. *3+ · quick*

## Learning Through Play

1. **Kitchen science: baking soda volcano.** *4+ · quick*
2. **Rainbow walking water.** Paper towels between cups of colored water. *4+ · medium (overnight)*
3. **Sink or float.** Guess first, then test household objects. *3+ · quick*
4. **Ice excavation.** Freeze small toys in ice; rescue them with warm water and salt. *3+ · project (overnight)*

5. **Grow a bean in a jar.** Watch roots appear over the break. *4+ · quick*
6. **Measure everything.** How many spoons long is the sofa? *4+ · quick*
7. **Shadow puppets** with a flashlight on the wall. *3+ · quick*
8. **Make a family tree** with photos or drawings. *5+ · medium*
9. **Learn ten words in a new language.** Label things around the house. *5+ · quick*
10. **Map your neighborhood.** Draw a map of your street or a walk you take. *6+ · medium*

## Family Connection and Giving Back

1. **Bake for a neighbor.** Deliver cookies with a handmade card. *3+ · medium*
2. **Toy clear-out for charity.** Choose toys to donate to children who need them. *4+ · medium*
3. **Write to grandparents** or older relatives. *4+ · quick*
4. **Family interview.** Kids interview parents: "What was your favorite toy? Your best holiday?" *5+ · quick*
5. **Look through old photos together** and tell the stories behind them. *3+ · quick*
6. **Kindness challenge.** One kind act per person per day. *4+ · quick*
7. **Family talent show.** Jokes, songs, cartwheels, magic tricks. *3+ · medium*
8. **Plan next year's adventure.** Where would you like to go? Make a wish list together. *4+ · quick*

9. **Make a time capsule** to open next winter. *5+ · medium*
10. **The "best of break" book.** Each day, draw or write one memory. Bind it at the end. *4+ · quick*

# Chapter 15: Making It Last Beyond the Break

When school starts again, it's tempting to slip back into old patterns. A few things will help you keep what worked:

- **Keep one or two "screen-free" anchors.** For example, no screens at dinner, or screen-free Sunday mornings.
- **Keep the invitation stations.** A basket of books and a box of art supplies in sight keep play going all year.
- **Hold a family review.** Ask: "What did we love about this break? What should we keep?"
- **Notice the wins.** Better sleep? Fewer meltdowns? More laughter? Name them out loud.

**Our family review**

**Our favorite moments this break:**

**What we want to keep doing:**

**Our screen agreement for school weeks:**

## A final word for parents

You don't have to be perfect to make a difference. Every walk, every board game, every afternoon in a blanket fort is a gift to your children: one they may not thank you for now, but that they will carry with them. And when the break is over and the house finally falls quiet, give yourself credit. You protected your family's time and attention in a world that constantly competes for it. That's no small thing.

# Printable Charts

## Daily Break Checklist (for kids)

☐ Got dressed

☐ Ate breakfast

☐ Helped with one chore

☐ Played outside

☐ Did something creative

☐ Read or listened to a story

☐ Did something kind

☐ Screen time (only after the basics!)

## Screen Time Tracker

**Mon: _____ Tue: _____ Wed: _____ Thu: _____**

**Fri: _____ Sat: _____ Sun: _____**

**What we did instead of screens this week:**

## Our Best of Break Memories

**Day 1:**

**Day 2:**

**Day 3:**

**Day 4:**

**Day 5:**

## Activity Wish List

Each family member writes three activities from this book they'd like to try.

# Chapter 16: Step-by-Step – 20 Family Favorites in Detail

Some activities are so good that they deserve more than one line. Here are twenty favorites from the list, with everything you need to make them work.

## 1. The Ultimate Blanket Fort

**You need:** chairs, a table, 3–4 blankets or sheets, clothespins or binder clips, cushions, fairy lights or a flashlight.

**How:** Push two chairs back to back with space between them, or use a table as the roof. Drape the biggest blanket over the top and clip it to the chair backs. Add smaller blankets as walls. Fill the inside with cushions. Let the children decide what the fort is: a castle, a spaceship, a bear cave.

**Make it last:** Leave the fort up for a few days. Read stories, eat snacks or watch a family film inside it.

## 2. Indoor Obstacle Course

**You need:** cushions, a broom, painter's tape, a laundry basket, soft toys.

**How:** Create stations: jump over the cushion "river," crawl under the broom held between two chairs, walk the tape line like a tightrope, throw three soft toys into the basket, then run back. Time each round.

**Make it last:** Let the children redesign the course and challenge you.

## 3. Salt Dough Ornaments

**You need:** 2 cups flour, 1 cup salt, about ¾ cup water, cookie cutters, a straw, paint.

**How:** Mix flour and salt, add water slowly and knead into a smooth dough. Roll it out, cut shapes, and use the straw to make a hole for hanging. Bake at a low temperature (around 120°C / 250°F) for 2–3 hours until hard, or air-dry for a couple of days. Paint when cool.

**Make it last:** Write the year on the back. Hang them every Christmas.

## 4. Homemade Play Dough

**You need:** 1 cup flour, ½ cup salt, 1 tablespoon oil, about ½ cup warm water, food coloring.

**How:** Mix the dry ingredients, add oil and colored water, and knead until soft. Add a little flour if sticky. Store in a sealed container.

**Play ideas:** bakery, pizza shop, monster making, letter shapes.

## 5. Ice Excavation

**You need:** a plastic container, water, small waterproof toys, salt, droppers or spoons, warm water.

**How:** Freeze toys in layers of water overnight. Pop the ice block onto a tray and let children "rescue" the toys using warm water and salt.

**Learning bonus:** Talk about why salt and warm water help ice melt.

## 6. Snow (or Rain) Day Science: Rainbow Walking Water

**You need:** 6 clear cups, paper towels, water, food coloring (red, yellow, blue).

**How:** Arrange cups in a circle. Fill every other cup with water and add a different color to each. Fold paper towel strips to connect each cup to the next. Watch over a few hours as the colors "walk" and mix in the empty cups.

## 7. Kids' Café

**You need:** paper, crayons, aprons, simple snacks.

**How:** Children design a menu with drawings and prices, set the table, take your "order" and serve snacks. Use play money or buttons to pay.

**Make it last:** Open the café every afternoon at 4 p.m. during the break.

## 8. Family Game Tournament

**You need:** 4–6 games (cards, board games, simple paper games), a chart on the fridge.

**How:** Play one game each day. Award points for winning and for good sportsmanship. Crown a champion at the end of the break with a homemade medal.

## 9. Treasure Hunt

**You need:** paper, a small prize (a sticker, a treat, a coupon for a special activity).

**How:** Write simple clues that lead from one spot to the next ("Where we keep the cold milk" for the fridge). For pre-readers, use drawings instead of words.

**Make it last:** Let older children write a hunt for younger siblings.

## 10. Cardboard Box City

**You need:** boxes of all sizes, tape, markers, scissors (adult help for cutting).

**How:** Turn boxes into houses, shops, a garage, a tunnel. Draw windows, doors and signs. Add toy cars and figures.

## 11. Puppet Show

**You need:** old socks or paper bags, buttons, yarn, glue, a table turned on its side or a cardboard stage.

**How:** Make puppets together, then write a simple story with a beginning, a problem and a happy ending. Perform it for the family, or for grandparents on a video call.

## 12. Nature Scavenger Hunt

**You need:** a list (written or drawn), a bag.

**How:** Find: a pinecone, something red, a smooth stone, three different leaves, a feather, something that smells nice, something tiny. Back home, arrange the finds into a picture or a display.

## 13. Bird Feeder Pinecones

**You need:** pinecones, string, peanut butter or seed butter, birdseed.

**How:** Tie string to each pinecone, spread with butter, roll in birdseed and hang outside a window. Keep a bird diary of who visits.

## 14. Story Chain

**You need:** nothing (or paper to write it down).

**How:** One person starts a story with one sentence. Each person adds the next sentence. Silly is good. Write down the best ones and illustrate them.

## 15. Kitchen Science: Volcano

**You need:** a cup or bottle, baking soda, vinegar, dish soap, food coloring, a tray.

**How:** Put 2 tablespoons of baking soda in the cup, add a drop of soap and coloring, then pour in vinegar and watch it erupt. Build a "volcano" around the cup with play dough for extra fun.

## 16. Kindness Challenge

**You need:** a list of small kind acts.

**How:** Every family member does one kind act a day: make someone's bed, draw a card for a neighbor, share a toy, help with dinner. Talk about it at dinner.

## 17. Family Talent Show

**You need:** a "stage" (a rug), a flashlight spotlight, a program written by the kids.

**How:** Everyone prepares one act: a joke, a song, a dance, a magic trick, a cartwheel. Make tickets and invite the cat.

## 18. Shadow Puppets

**You need:** a flashlight or lamp, a blank wall, your hands.

**How:** Make a dog, a bird, a rabbit. Cut animal shapes from cardboard and tape them to sticks for more characters. Turn off the lights and tell a story.

## 19. The Time Capsule

**You need:** a box or jar, paper, photos, small objects.

**How:** Each person writes or draws: my favorite food, my best friend, what I want to be, my height. Add a photo and a small treasure. Seal it and write "Open next winter" on the lid.

## 20. Best-of-Break Memory Book

**You need:** paper, stapler or ribbon, crayons, photos if you have them.

**How:** At the end of each day, each child draws or writes one memory. On the last day, bind the pages into a little book. Read it together on the first evening back at school.

# Chapter 17: A Sample 14-Day Winter Break Plan

Here is one example of how two weeks might look. Change everything to suit your family. The idea is a gentle structure, not a timetable.

**Day 1 (Monday) – Maker Day:** family meeting about the break plan; salt dough ornaments; screen window after lunch; story chain at bedtime.

**Day 2 – Kitchen Day:** pizza faces for lunch; homemade play dough; walk to look at holiday lights.

**Day 3 – Adventure Day:** library visit; nature scavenger hunt in the park; family game tournament begins.

**Day 4 – Game Day:** board game in the morning; treasure hunt; video call with grandparents.

**Day 5 – Fort & Film Night:** build the ultimate blanket fort; family movie inside the fort.

**Day 6 – Weekend:** slow morning; long walk or sledding; baking for a neighbor.

**Day 7 – Weekend:** visit relatives (bring the activity bag); quiet evening with audiobooks.

**Day 8 – Science Day:** ice excavation (freeze the night before); rainbow walking water; volcano.

**Day 9 – Café Day:** the kids' café opens; puppet making; puppet show in the evening.

**Day 10 – Adventure Day:** a new playground or a museum; bird feeder pinecones.

**Day 11 – Kindness Day:** kindness challenge; toy clear-out for charity; cards for neighbors.

**Day 12 – Show Day:** family talent show rehearsals and performance.

**Day 13 – Weekend:** outdoor day; cardboard box city in the afternoon.

**Day 14 – Weekend:** time capsule; bind the best-of-break memory book; family review and plans for school weeks.

## Our own 14-day plan

**Day 1:** [[lines:1]]

**Day 2:** [[lines:1]]

**Day 3:** [[lines:1]]

**Day 4:** [[lines:1]]

**Day 5:** [[lines:1]]

**Day 6:** [[lines:1]]

**Day 7:** [[lines:1]]

**Day 8:** [[lines:1]]

**Day 9:** [[lines:1]]

**Day 10:** [[lines:1]]

**Day 11:** [[lines:1]]

**Day 12:** [[lines:1]]

**Day 13:** [[lines:1]]

**Day 14:** [[lines:1]]

# Chapter 18: For You, the Parent

There's one more person whose relationship with screens matters during the break: you. Children learn far more from what we do than from what we say. If our phones are always in our hands, our rules about their screens will feel unfair, and they'll be right.

This isn't about guilt. Most parents use their phones for good reasons: work, family logistics, staying in touch, a moment of rest. But it helps to notice your own patterns, too.

## Small changes that make a big difference

- **Phone-free meals** for everyone.
- **A "phone parking spot"** in the kitchen, so your phone isn't in your pocket all day.
- **Say out loud what you're doing:** "I'm checking the weather for our walk," so children see purposeful use, not endless scrolling.
- **Protect your own rest.** If you need ten minutes of quiet, take it. A rested parent handles the hard moments better.
- **Be kind to yourself on the hard days.** Some days will go off-plan. That's normal. Tomorrow is a fresh start.

## Practice: My own break goals

**One way I'll model calmer screen use:**

**One thing I'll do just for me this break:**

**What I want my kids to remember about this break:**

# Chapter 19: Big Feelings When Everyone Is Home

Holidays are wonderful, and they are also intense. Routines change, sleep shifts, sugar flows freely, relatives visit, and everyone is together in the same rooms all day. It's no surprise that tempers flare, for children and adults alike. Screens are often used to calm things down. Here are other tools that work.

## Connection before correction

When a child is upset, their thinking brain is offline for a moment. Lectures don't land. What helps first is connection:

- Get down to their level.
- Name what you see: "You're really frustrated. The tower fell down again."
- Keep your voice low and slow. Your calm is borrowed by their nervous system.
- Wait. Most big feelings pass faster when they're met rather than fought.

Once they're calmer, you can talk about what happened and what to do next time.

## A calm corner

Create a cozy space where anyone, child or adult, can go to settle: a beanbag or cushions, a soft blanket, a few books, a squishy toy,

headphones with calm music, a picture card with breathing ideas. It's not a punishment spot. It's a place to come back to yourself.

## Breathing games for kids

Children rarely respond to "calm down and breathe." They do respond to play:

- **Birthday candles:** hold up five fingers and blow out each "candle" slowly.
- **Hot cocoa breath:** smell the cocoa (breathe in through the nose), cool it down (breathe out through the mouth).
- **Balloon belly:** put a hand on the tummy and fill it like a balloon, then let the air out slowly.
- **Snake breath:** breathe in, then breathe out with a long "sssss."

Practice these when everyone is calm, so they're familiar when they're needed.

## Movement resets

Sometimes a body needs to move to feel better. Try a dance break, ten jumping jacks, a run to the end of the garden and back, or a "shake it out" song. Many meltdowns in the late afternoon are simply bodies that haven't moved enough.

## When you lose your temper

You will, at some point. Every parent does. What matters most is repair:

> *"I'm sorry I shouted. I was frustrated, but shouting wasn't okay. Can we try again?"*

Repair teaches children that relationships can survive hard moments, and that grown-ups take responsibility too.

## Practice: Our calm-down menu

Write five things that help each member of your family calm down. Put the list in your calm corner.

# Chapter 20: Siblings, Squabbles and Sharing Space

More time together often means more arguments. That doesn't mean the break is going badly. Siblings are learning to negotiate, share and solve problems, and that learning is noisy.

## Prevent the predictable fights

- **Give each child a "mine" space** for special toys that don't have to be shared.
- **Use a timer for turns** with popular toys or games.
- **Plan one-on-one time** with each child, even 15 minutes a day. Many sibling fights are really a bid for a parent's attention.
- **Separate before it escalates:** "I can see this is getting hard. Let's take a break in different rooms for ten minutes."

## Coach, don't judge

When you weren't there to see who started it, avoid playing referee. Instead, describe the problem and hand it back:

> *"I see two kids and one scooter. That's a tricky problem. What ideas do you have?"*

Children often come up with surprisingly fair solutions when they're trusted to try.

## Team challenges

Activities that require cooperation turn rivals into teammates: building one big fort together, a joint treasure hunt, a two-person cooking project, or a "beat the timer" tidy-up race against the clock rather than each other.

## Practice: Our sibling plan

**Each child's "mine" toys:**

_____

_____

**One-on-one time for each child (when?):**

_____

_____

**Team challenge we'll try:**

_____

_____

# Chapter 21: Rainy Weeks and Sick Days

Some breaks don't go to plan. A stomach bug, a week of rain, a parent with the flu. On these days, it's absolutely fine for screens to play a bigger role. Rest matters more than rules.

## When a child is sick

- Let them rest. Sleep and quiet are the priority.
- Gentle activities help when they're bored but not well: audiobooks, sticker books, simple puzzles, coloring, listening to music, being read to.
- Screens can be a comfort. Choose calm, slower shows and keep the volume low.
- Return to the usual rhythm gradually once they're feeling better.

## When you're sick

Lower every standard. Order food if you can. Ask for help. Put on a film, set out snacks and a busy box, and rest on the sofa nearby. Your children will remember being cared for, not how many hours of screen time they had.

## A rainy-week emergency kit

Keep a box ready for days when you're stuck inside: a new craft kit, a pack of play dough, a new deck of cards, a puzzle, painter's tape for

floor games, a few new library books, and a list of indoor games in the 100-activity list.

# Chapter 22: Back to School Without the Battle

The last few days of the break can be bumpy, especially if sleep and routines have drifted. A gentle transition makes the first school morning much easier.

## Three days before school

- **Shift bedtime back** by 15–20 minutes each evening.
- **Bring back the school-day rhythm:** breakfast at the usual time, getting dressed early.
- **Talk about what's coming:** friends they'll see, things they're looking forward to, anything they're worried about.

## The night before

- Pack bags and lay out clothes together.
- Keep the evening calm and screen-free.
- Read the best-of-break memory book you made together.

## Keep one thing from the break

Ask the family: "What's one thing from this break we want to keep?" Maybe it's Friday fort night, a weekly game evening, or phone-free dinners. Write it down and put it on the fridge.

**The one thing we're keeping from this break:**

# Chapter 23: Screen-Free Evenings and Calmer Bedtimes

Evenings are often when screens creep back in. Everyone is tired, dinner needs making, and a show seems like the easiest way through. But screens in the last hour before bed tend to make settling harder: the content is exciting, the light is bright, and stopping often triggers protest just when everyone needs calm.

## A wind-down rhythm

Try a simple, predictable sequence that children can learn by heart:

1. **Tidy-up song** (five minutes, everyone helps)
2. **Bath or wash**
3. **Pajamas and teeth**
4. **A warm drink or small snack**
5. **Two stories** (or one chapter for older children)
6. **One question to talk about:** "What was the best part of your day?" "What made you laugh?"
7. **Lights low, a soft song or audiobook**

The order matters less than the repetition. When the steps are always the same, children know what's coming and resist less.

## Evening activities that calm instead of excite

- Drawing or coloring at the kitchen table
- Puzzles
- Reading together on the sofa
- Gentle stretching or "animal yoga"
- Listening to an audiobook in the dark
- Looking at family photo albums
- Writing in the best-of-break memory book

## When older children want their devices at night

For tweens, agree that phones and tablets "sleep" outside the bedroom, charging in the kitchen. Present it as a family rule that adults follow too, rather than a punishment. Offer an alarm clock and a book light so the phone isn't needed.

## Practice: Our bedtime steps

# Chapter 24: New Family Traditions Without Screens

The best holiday memories are rarely of what was on a screen. They're of the smell of cookies, the cold air on a night walk, a silly game that made everyone cry with laughter. Traditions give children something to look forward to every year, and they're easy to start.

## Ideas to try

- **The first-snow cocoa:** whenever the first snow falls, everyone drops what they're doing for hot chocolate.
- **Christmas Eve box:** pajamas, a book and a treat to open on Christmas Eve.
- **A family lights walk:** a yearly walk or drive to see the best-decorated houses.
- **Kindness advent:** one small kind act each day in December.
- **Cookie decorating night** with music and too many sprinkles.
- **The family "year in review":** on New Year's Eve, each person shares their favorite memory of the year.
- **Gratitude chain:** a paper chain where each link holds something you're thankful for.
- **New Year's Day walk:** start the year outdoors, together.

## Making a tradition stick

Choose just one or two. Do them every year, at the same time, in the same way. Give them a name. Take a photo each year in the same

spot. Children love seeing how much they've grown.

**The tradition we're starting this year:**

**When we'll do it:**

**What makes it special:**

# Chapter 25: Questions Parents Often Ask

**"My child says everyone else gets unlimited screen time. What do I say?"**

Stay calm and kind: "Every family makes its own rules. In our family, we have screen time after lunch, and lots of other fun things too." You don't need to defend your choice or criticize other families. Consistency matters more than winning the argument.

**"What if my child just sits and does nothing when the screen goes off?"**

That's okay. Doing nothing is often the step before doing something. Resist filling the gap immediately. Leave inviting materials nearby and give it ten to fifteen minutes. If they're still stuck, offer a choice of two activities rather than an open question.

**"Isn't some screen time educational?"**

Some is, especially when it's chosen with intention and talked about afterwards. The problem is rarely one good documentary; it's the endless stream that follows it. Choose, watch, switch off, then do something with what you learned.

**"My teenager needs their phone to stay in touch with friends. Is that okay?"**

Yes. Friendships are important, and for many teens messaging is how they connect. Agree on times and phone-free zones together rather than banning the phone. Invite friends over for real-world plans, too.

**"I work from home. Is this realistic for me?"**

Yes, with a different plan. Read the working parent's chapter: planned screen time during your most important hours, independent play stations, short connection breaks and shared childcare. Aim for a better balance, not perfection.

**"What if grandparents give the kids tablets as Christmas presents?"**

Thank them warmly. Then decide where the tablet lives and when it's used, just like any other device in your home. A new device doesn't need to change your family's rhythm.

**"We tried, and the first day was a disaster. Should we give up?"**

The first days are almost always the hardest. Keep the rhythm, lower your expectations, and look for small wins. Most families notice a real shift after about three to four days.

**"How do I handle my own phone habits?"**

Gently, without guilt. Pick one or two changes, like phone-free meals or a phone parking spot, and tell your children what you're doing. They'll notice, and it makes your rules feel fair.

**"Is it bad to use a screen when I'm exhausted?"**

No. A show that gives you a quiet half hour is a reasonable tool, especially on hard days. The goal is a break that feels balanced overall, not a perfect score every day.

**"When should I worry?"**

If screen use comes with extreme distress, withdrawal from friends and activities, serious sleep problems, or signs that something upsetting happened online, talk to your child's doctor or a family professional. Reaching out early is always okay.

# A Final Word

You picked up this book because you wanted something better for your children's time off: more laughter, more play, more of the kind of memories that stay. That wish is already the most important part.

Some days of the break will be magical. Some will be loud, messy and full of complaints. Both are part of a real family holiday. What your children will remember is not a perfect plan, but the feeling of a parent who chose to be there with them, building the fort, losing at cards, sweeping up the flour.

Thank you for giving them that. Their wonder was never gone. It just needed a little space.

With warmth,

*Clara*

# Where to Go From Here

You made it through this book, and that is more than most people ever do. If you'd like to take the next step:

- *I Didn't Mean to Yell* (coming soon): for moms who love fiercely and lose their temper anyway
- *Brave Little Hearts* (coming soon): helping your anxious child grow courage, one small step at a time

## More Gentle Life Guides

- *Still Lit*: for single women who feel alone at Christmas
- *Who Takes Care of Mom?* (coming soon): a 30-day reset for women carrying the invisible load
- *The Woman Who Started Over* (coming soon): rebuilding your life and your children's sense of home after divorce

You can find every guide on Amazon by searching for "Clara Whitfield".

## A Small Favor

If even one page of this book helped you, would you consider leaving an honest review on Amazon? It takes a minute, and it helps someone else find a book that might help them too.